

Chalcidian helmet
Once thought to have originated in the Greek city of Chalcis, this ornate style of helmet was made in the Greek colonies of southern Italy in the 5th century BCE.

The Persians were unaccustomed to the Greeks' aggressive use of infantry, depending more upon archers, cavalry, and chariots. Despite their surprise at the tactics of the hoplites, they succeeded in routing the Greek centre, but stronger Greek forces on each wing drove into the Persian flanks, forcing them to flee to their boats. The second invasion in 480 BCE was the occasion of the celebrated fight to the death by 300 Spartan hoplites holding the narrow pass at Thermopylae. Soon after this delaying action the Persian fleet was decisively defeated at Salamis, and the following year combined Greek forces won victories over the Persians on land at the battles of Plataea and Mycale.

AUXILIARY TROOPS

Although the defeat of the Persians was a tribute to the courage and fighting skills of the armoured citizen-soldier, the account of the battles by Greek historian Herodotus makes it clear that many light troops fought on the Greek side. He states, for example, that "35,000 lightly armed helots" supported the 5,000 Spartan hoplites at Platea and that the Athenian forces at the same battle included 800 archers. In the course of the Peloponnesian Wars these skirmishers seem to have grown in importance. An example of the use of light troops – and of the pitiless brutality of Greek warfare – is given by Thucydides, who relates that in 459 BCE the Athenians managed to trap a large number of fleeing Corinthians and "surrounding the enclosure with light-armed troops, stoned to death all who were inside". The most famous skirmishers were Thracian peltasts. Wearing a flimsy tunic and carrying a light wicker shield, these fleet-footed soldiers harassed the enemy phalanx by throwing javelins into their midst. Slow-moving hoplites, overburdened with heavy shields and armour, were vulnerable to this form of attack. Fighting in the service of Athens, peltasts famously annihilated a Spartan hoplite brigade outside Corinth in 390 BCE.

> "WE … ARE TO FIGHT MEDES AND PERSIANS, NATIONS LONG STEEPED IN LUXURY, WHILE WE HAVE LONG BEEN HARDENED BY WARLIKE TOILS AND DANGERS … IT WILL BE A FIGHT OF FREE MEN AGAINST SLAVES."
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> **ALEXANDER THE GREAT**, ADDRESSING HIS ARMY BEFORE THE BATTLE OF ISSUS, 333 BCE



Battle of Issus
Long Macedonian-style "sarissa" spears are a prominent feature in this depiction of Alexander the Great's defeat of the Persian king Darius in 333 BCE.